



Heard

You are heard.

End user profile

Meet Yejin — a solo florist who has no one to hear her out.



Yejin Kim (pseudonym) · 38 · Seoul, Mapo-gu

Solo florist, 4th year running her shop Bosong.

Demographics

Married, one child in elementary school. Revenue ≈ 6M KRW/mo, net ≈ 1.5M. Six days a week, ~65 hours.

Daily routine

5 AM market → 8 AM prep → 9 AM open → 8 PM close → 10 PM Instagram → midnight sleep.

Psychographics

Perfectionist. One complaint keeps her awake for days. Posts only happy photos. Tells her husband "it's going well." Tried ChatGPT once; gave up because she had to re-explain everything every time.

Behavior

Silent member of Apeunikka Sajangida (1.4M). Replies to reviews between 11 PM and midnight. Thinks "am I going to have to close?" two or three times a week.

"At night, lying in bed, I keep replaying whether I made the right call today. There's no one I can say it to."

One of 1.4M members of Apeunikka Sajangida ("Being a boss hurts") — Korea's largest solo-business community, which exists precisely because its members have nowhere else to be heard. (left image was generated by Gemini 2.5-Pro (Nano-Banana-2))

Problem

She carries every decision alone — and no one is listening.

SCALE

911,000 Korean businesses closed in 2023 — a 9.5% closure rate.
Small-business closure insurance payouts exceeded **100,000** cases for the first time.
1.4M+ members in Korea's leading solo-business community — because there is nowhere else to vent. *FSC 2023; MSS 2024.*

VOICES

posts that go unheard

*"This might be my last week."
"Closing my café after 6 years."
"Revenue keeps dropping and I don't know why." *Hankyung Business, 2023.**

WHY

Decision loneliness → judgment fatigue → burnout → business exit.
"Loneliness impacts solo self-employed performance far more severely than employees or leaders." — JSBM 2025.

WHY EXISTING SOLUTIONS FAIL

Therapy

73% of Koreans with mental-health concerns never see a professional. *MOHW 2024*

Coaching

Too expensive, and its schedule never fits hers.

ChatGPT

Forgets context — she re-explains herself every session.

A quiet ear that hears her — and gives her own words back when she needs them.

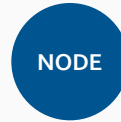


Low-effort voice input

- Tap-to-talk on a Bluetooth earbud or clip-on mic — never always-on.
- On-device STT (Whisper-small class).
- Auto-categorizes into {customer, stock, pricing, mood, decision}.

WHY IT WORKS

Pennebaker: putting thoughts into language reduces stress. Speaking carries the same mechanism, without the typing over head.



Domain-specific memory

- Not a generic vector DB.
- Memory nodes tailored to solo retail: {regular customer, restock, price change, complaint, seasonality}
- Retrieval indexed along time and relationship axes.

WHY IT WORKS

This is the patentable core of Heard.



Reflective response

- A generic chatbot says: "You should raise prices."
- Heard says: "Last May you faced the same dilemma. You raised by 500 won and left a note for regulars. You logged almost no churn. What feels different this time?"

WHY IT WORKS

100% on-device. Nothing leaves the phone. What you say stays with you — and comes back only to you.

A day of being heard — through Yejin's ear.

hardware: earbud · phone · clip-on mic

06:20

YANGJAE FLOWER MARKET

Yejin "Roses jumped again today — but the color's prettier than last April."

Heard (quietly logs — stock:rose, price↑, quality↑, date:today)

14:30

SHOP · A REGULAR WALKS OUT EMPTY-HANDED

Yejin "Grandma Park comes every week — she just left without buying. Probably because I was out of pink roses."

Heard (logs — customer:regular_Park, event:no_purchase, inferred_cause:stockout)

22:40

CLOSING · PRICING DILEMMA

Yejin "Should I raise rose prices tomorrow? Regulars might stop coming."

Heard "Last April you had the same dilemma. You raised by 500 won and left a note for regulars. Almost no churn. What feels different this time?"

23:15

BEFORE BED

Yejin "Today was rough. Grandma Park leaving stuck with me."

Heard (kept. no advice. no judgment.)

06:30

NEXT MORNING · WALKING TO MARKET

Heard "Yesterday you mentioned three stock worries. Want me to bring them up before you buy today?"

WITHOUT HEARD

- ChatGPT forgets by morning.
- A notebook needs energy she doesn't have at 11 PM.
- Community posts wait hours for a reply.

None of them actually hear her.

To be heard is to decide better, burn out less, and stay longer in business.

TIER 1 · INDIVIDUAL Individual • Feeling heard. Being genuinely heard lowers emotional reactivity and improves decision quality, even without advice.	TIER 2 · SOCIETAL Societal • Closure crisis. Softens Korea's 910K-per-year business closures by addressing decision isolation upstream. • Mental-health gap. Bridges the gap between the 73.6% reporting concerns and the 27% who seek professional help. • Safety net. An emotional safety net for solo operators with no coworkers, no staff, no one to check in with.	TIER 3 · TECHNICAL Technical • Memory schema. A transferable domain-specific personal-memory schema, generalizable to hairdressers, craftmakers, solo clinicians. • On-device arch. An on-device personalized-LLM privacy architecture. • Speech pipeline. A pipeline that auto-structures unstructured everyday speech into actionable memory.
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PROTOTYPE KPIs weekly utterance count · self-resolved decision rate · pre/post PSS delta · 4-week retention

In five years, Heard becomes the quiet companion for 100,000 Korean solo shopkeepers — a million words spoken, a million words returned.

Why this opportunity

Why now, why this user, why this gap, why us.

WHY NOW

- On-device small LLMs (Gemma, Phi, Qwen) finally usable on mobile in 2024.
- Whisper-class STT runs on-device in real time.
- The privacy–performance trade-off is resolved. Voices can be heard without being uploaded.

WHY THIS USER

- Solo self-employed loneliness is more severe than employee or leader loneliness (JSBM 2025).
- 1.4M+ members in Korea's largest solo-business community alone.
- 73.6% report mental-health concerns but only 27% seek help — a non-clinical way to feel heard is missing.

WHY NOBODY DID IT

- VC avoids 1-person SMB markets: low ACV, fragmented.
- Enterprise AI targets corporations and knowledge workers.
- Korean self-employed AI (e.g., DaekgeulMong) focuses on external response — not internal decision-making.
- The "quietly listening to the shopkeeper herself" quadrant is structurally vacant.

WHY US

- Korean language and Korean self-employed context as a defensible moat.
- NLP, personalization, multimodal background from an AI PhD program matches the stack.
- Three patentable elements: (a) memory-graph extraction from speech, (b) reflective-response policy, (c) selective on-device retention.

COMPETITIVE MATRIX
target user (x) × focus (y)



Next step

From proposal to prototype — Week 8.

01 MVP scope

Text input first; voice in v2.

On-device simulated; true on-device in v3.

Single-user self-test as a proxy for Yejin.

02 Validation plan

Pilot with 2–3 florists or café owners over 2 weeks.

Pre/post PSS survey (Perceived Stress Scale).

Qualitative coding of moments users say they felt heard.

03 Stack candidates

STT Whisper-small

LLM Gemma 2B or Qwen 1.5B, on-device

Vector store ChromaDB, local

App React Native + Expo

KNOWN LIMITATIONS *Korean only initially. Schema hardcoded for floristry. Voice input deferred to v2.*

You are heard.